

Cybersecurity for SME Employees

Module 4.1 – Types of Sensitive Data

1 Objective

Introduce employees to the various categories of sensitive data handled in the workplace and explain why protecting this information is critical for businesses and customers alike.

2 Introduction

Every business stores and processes information that, if exposed, could lead to significant harm. Knowing what counts as “sensitive” data is the first step toward protecting it. Employees play a key role in identifying and safeguarding this data.

3 What is Sensitive Data?

Sensitive data refers to any information that must be protected from unauthorized access to maintain privacy, integrity, and security. This includes:

- Personally Identifiable Information (PII)
- Financial and payment information
- Business and proprietary data
- Health and employee records

4 1. Personally Identifiable Information (PII)

- Full name, home address, phone number
- Government-issued IDs (e.g., Aadhaar, PAN, passport)
- Date of birth, login credentials
- Biometric data (fingerprints, facial recognition)

5 2. Financial and Payment Information

- Credit/debit card details
- Bank account numbers and IFSC codes

- UPI credentials or digital wallet access
- Salary and compensation records

6 3. Business and Proprietary Information

- Internal strategy documents and pricing models
- Vendor or partner contracts
- Intellectual property (IP), patents, or trade secrets
- Customer databases and client contact details

7 4. Employee and Health Records

- Employment contracts
- Performance reviews
- Health insurance or medical leave documents
- Emergency contact information

8 Why is this Data Targeted?

Cybercriminals can use sensitive data for:

- Identity theft and fraud
- Financial gain through extortion or resale
- Competitive advantage via espionage
- Reputational damage to the company

9 Employee Responsibility

- Handle data carefully—only access what you need.
- Don't share sensitive information over unsecured channels.
- Lock screens and storage when not in use.
- Report any accidental exposure or suspicious access.

10 Conclusion

Understanding what qualifies as sensitive data is foundational to data protection. If you don't know whether data is sensitive—assume it is and treat it with care. In the next module, we'll explore best practices for securely handling this data in daily workflows.